

Japanese accusative/ablative alternation verbs are unaccusative

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This paper concerns a small group of Japanese verbs that license a morphological case alternation between accusative case and ablative (postpositional) case (Fukuda 2020; Kuno 1973; Teramura 1982).¹ I will call them *Accusative/Ablative Alternation Verbs*, or simply *Alternation Verbs*. These verbs describe motions of departure, like *hanareru* ‘leave’ in (1). I refer to *Taro* in (1) as the *leaver*, and to *mura* ‘village’ as the *source*. As exemplified in (1), Alternation Verbs allow the source phrase to be marked with either the accusative case *o* or the ablative postposition *kara*.

- (1) Taro-ga mura-{o/kara} hanare-ta.
Taro-NOM village-{ACC/from} leave-PAST
‘Taro left the village.’

The primary goal of this paper is to identify the argument structures projected by Alternation Verbs that give rise to the two variants of the case alternation. I will argue that these verbs project a unified, dyadic unaccusative structure without thematic Voice (Kratzer 1996). Example (1) has the structure (2).

- (2) [_{VP} [_{VP} Taro-NOM [_{NP/PP} village-NOM/from] $\sqrt{\text{LEAVE}}$] v]

Alternation Verbs are thus an example of verbs that introduce accusative-marked arguments despite not projecting a typical transitive argument structure (Alexiadou and Anagnostopoulou 2019; Schäfer 2025).

This paper is structured as follows. In Section 1, I argue that the source of Alternation Verbs is always an argument, no matter its case marking. In Section 2, I argue that Alternation Verbs don’t project thematic Voice no matter the case marking on the source. Putting these two arguments together, we arrive at the dyadic unaccusative argument structure in (2). In Section 3, I describe a dependent case-theoretic (Baker 2015; Baker and Vinokurova 2010; Marantz 1991) account of the accusative/ablative alternation. I conclude in Section 4.

1 The source is always an argument

In this section, I present evidence from ellipsis and long-distance scrambling which shows that the source phrase of an Alternation Verb is always an argument, not an adjunct, no matter if it is marked accusative or ablative. Assuming that the leaver is also always an argument, these facts suggest that Alternation Verbs project a unified *dyadic* structure.

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1.1 Ellipsis

Funakoshi (2016) states the generalization (3) concerning ellipsis in Japanese.

- (3) An adjunct can be elided only if no other VP-internal elements are present.

A consequence of (3) is that an adjunct can't be elided when an overt second VP-adjunct is present. Consider (4). Assume the verb *hatarakanakatta* 'didn't work' evacuates the VP. The reading illustrated in (4) assumes that there is no ellipsis in the second clause. A potential alternative interpretation is (5), where the second clause contains an elided adjunct, *teineini* 'carefully'. However, by (3), the ellipsis in (5) is impossible. This is because another VP-adjunct, *subayaku* 'quickly', remains unelided. The lack of this interpretation is evidenced by the fact that continuing the string in (4)/(5) with (6) is judged contradictory: this continuation is only compatible with the unavailable ellipsis interpretation (5).

- (4) Taro-wa subayaku teineini hataraita ga, Hanako-wa [_{VP} subayaku] hatarakanakatta.
Taro-TOP quickly carefully worked but Hanako-TOP quickly didn't work
'Taro worked quickly and carefully, but Hanako didn't work quickly.'
- (5) * ... Hanako-wa [_{VP} subayaku <teineini>] hatarakanakatta.
... Hanako-TOP quickly carefully didn't work
'... Hanako didn't work quickly <and-carefully>.'
- (6) # Hanako worked quickly, but she didn't work carefully.

On the other hand, an argument can be elided even if an overt VP-adjunct is present. So, (7) is compatible with the indicated ellipsis interpretation, where the argument *zibun-no kuruma-o* 'one's own car' is elided. If this interpretation weren't available, the string in (7) should entail that Hanako didn't wash anything. As a matter of fact, it is available: the continuation (8) doesn't contradict the string in (7).

- (7) Taro-wa teineini zibun-no kuruma-o aratta ga, Hanako-wa [_{VP} teineini <zibun-no>
Taro-TOP carefully self-'s car-ACC washed but Hanako-TOP carefully self-'s
<kuruma-o>] arawanakatta.
car-ACC didn't wash
'Taro washed his car carefully, but Hanako didn't wash her car <carefully>.'
- (8) ✓ Hanako washed her bike carefully.

What I have just shown is that Funakoshi's generalization (3) can be used as an argumenthood diagnostic. Consider (9), where we apply this diagnostic to an Alternation Verb, *deru* 'exit'. The indicated ellipsis interpretation is available, since the continuation (10) is judged non-contradictory, no matter if the source *eki* is marked with the accusative or the ablative. This suggests that the source is always an argument, no matter its marking.

- (9) Taro-wa suguni eki-{o/kara} deta ga, Hanako-wa [_{VP} suguni <eki-{o/kara}>]
Taro-TOP quickly station-{ACC/from} exited but Hanako-TOP quickly station-{ACC/from}
denakatta.
didn't exit
'Taro exited the station quickly, but Hanako didn't exit <the-station> quickly.'
- (10) ✓ Hanako exited the ticket gate quickly, but she took time to exit the station.

1.2 Long-distance scrambling

Long-distance scrambling is scrambling out of a clausal category. Saito (1985) shows that arguments can undergo long-distance scrambling, while true adjuncts can't. Thus, (11) is grammatical, because the scrambled phrase *Bill-ga* 'Bill' is an argument in its clause. On the other hand, (12) is ungrammatical, because *sono riyuu-de* 'for that reason' is an adjunct.

- (11) Bill-ga₁ John-wa [*t*₁ gakkoo-de Mary-ni kisu-sita koto] o Jane-ni osieta.
Bill-NOM John-TOP school-at Mary-DAT kissed fact ACC Jane-DAT told
'John told Jane that Bill kissed Mary at school.'
- (12) ?* [Sono riyuu-de]₁ Mary-ga [Bill-ga *t*₁ kubininatta to] omotteiru (koto)
that reason-for Mary-NOM Bill-NOM was fired COMP thinks (fact)
'(the fact that) Mary thinks Bill was fired for that reason'

Example (13) shows that the source phrase *mura-{o/kara}* '(from) the village' of the Alternation Verb *hanareta* 'left' can undergo long-distance scrambling, thus indicating that it is not an adjunct. This is the case no matter if the source is marked accusative or ablative.

- (13) Mura-{o/kara}₁ Taro-wa [Hanako-ga *t*₁ hanareta to] itta.
Village-{ACC/from} Taro-TOP Hanako-NOM left COMP said
'Taro said Hanako left the village.'

Thus, I conclude that the source phrase of an Alternation Verb is always an argument, no matter if it is marked accusative or ablative.

2 There is never thematic Voice

In this section, I present evidence from passivization and the accusative *wh*-adjunct which shows that Alternation Verbs never project thematic Voice, regardless of the case-marking on the source. These facts suggest that Alternation Verbs project an *unaccusative* structure.

2.1 Passivization

If Alternation Verbs project thematic Voice, we expect them to undergo passivization. At first glance, this seems to borne out: (14) is grammatical, where the Alternation Verb *hanareta* 'leave' appears with the passive morpheme *-rare-*, with dative marking on the leaver.

- (14) Sono mura-ga Taro-ni hanare-rare-ta.
That village-NOM Taro-DAT leave-PASS-PAST
'That village was left by Taro.'

Japanese distinguishes two kinds of passives: *direct passives* and *indirect passives*. They look similar, because both constructions use the passive morpheme *-rare-* and involve similar case-marking patterns. It is direct passivization that we only expect a verb with thematic Voice to possibly undergo. Indirect passivization is a construction that introduces a malefactive argument, and is available to all sorts of verbs, including unaccusatives (15). It isn't a valency-decreasing operation: (16) shows an indirect passive of the transitive verb *sikaru* 'scold', where there are a total of three arguments.

- (15) Taro-ga ame-ni hu-rare-ta.
Taro-NOM rain-DAT fall-PASS-PAST
'Taro got rained on.'
- (16) Taro-ga kodomo-o sensei-ni sika-rare-ta.
Taro-NOM child-ACC teacher-DAT scold-PASS-PAST
'Taro got his child scolded by the teacher.'

In fact, (14) is an indirect passive, not a direct one. The evidence comes from established diagnostics that distinguish the two passives. For example, direct passives allow the dative marker *ni* to be replaced with a different marker, *niyotte* (17), while indirect passives don't allow this ((Jo and Seo 2023); 18, 19). The leaver of an Alternation Verb can't be marked with *niyotte* (20).

- (17) Taro-ga sensei-niyotte sika-rare-ta.
Taro-NOM teacher-NIYOTTE scold-PASS-PAST
'Taro was scolded by the teacher.'
- (18) *Taro-ga ame-niyotte hu-rare-ta.
Taro-NOM rain-NIYOTTE fall-PASS-PAST
'Taro got rained on.'
- (19) *Taro-ga kodomo-o sensei-niyotte sika-rare-ta.
Taro-NOM child-ACC teacher-NIYOTTE scold-PASS-PAST
'Taro got his child scolded by the teacher.'
- (20) *Sono mura-ga Taro-niyotte hanare-rare-ta.
That village-NOM Taro-NIYOTTE leave-PASS-PAST
'That village was left by Taro.'

When the dative-marked argument of a direct passive is omitted (21), that argument has an existential interpretation (Bruening 2013) and can antecede sluicing (Akkus 2021). Neither is possible for Alternation Verbs (22). This suggests that Alternation Verbs never project thematic Voice.

- (21) Taro-ga sika-rare-ta ga, dare-ni <sika-rare-ta> ka siranai.
Taro-NOM scold-PASS-PAST but, who-DAT scold-PASS-PAST Q don't know
'Taro got scolded (by someone), but I don't know by who.'
- (22) Sono mura-ga hana-rare-ta ga, #dare-ni <hana-rare-ta> ka siranai.
That village-NOM leave-PASS-PAST but, who-DAT leave-PASS-PAST Q don't know
'The village was left (by #someone), #but I don't know by who.'

2.2 The accusative *wh*-adjunct *nani-o* 'what-ACC'

Kurafuji (1997) shows that the phrase *nani-o* 'what-ACC', which he calls the *accusative wh-adjunct*, can mean 'why' when it appears with unergative (23) and transitive verbs (24), but not with unaccusatives (25).

- (23) Nani-o Taro-wa sawai-deir-u no?
What-ACC Taro-TOP make noises-PROG-PRES Q
'Why is Taro making noises?'
- (24) Nani-o Taro-wa henna uta-o utat-teir-u no?
What-ACC Taro-TOP weird song-ACC sing-PROG-PRES Q
'Why is Taro singing weird songs?'

- (25) * Nani-o densya-wa itumo okurete kuru no?
 What-ACC train-TOP always late arrive Q
 Intended: ‘Why do trains always arrive late?’

Alternation Verbs don’t allow this interpretation of the phrase (26), patterning with unaccusatives. This is the case no matter whether the source is marked accusative or ablative.

- (26) * Nani-o Taro-wa mura-{o/kara} hanare-teir-u no?
 What-ACC Taro-TOP village-{ACC/from} leave-PROG-PRES Q
 Intended: ‘Why is Taro leaving the village?’

I thus conclude that Alternation Verbs never project thematic Voice, no matter the source marking. This tells us that the leaver must always be an internal argument, making Alternation Verbs dyadic unaccusative verbs. We thus arrive at (2), the structure I proposed for (1), repeated below. Both the leaver and the source are merged within VP. The source is either a NP or a PP: it is marked accusative when it is a NP and ablative when it is a PP.

- (2) [_{VP} [_{VP} Taro-NOM [_{NP/PP} village-ACC/from] $\sqrt{\text{LEAVE}}$] v]

This unified unaccusative proposal differs from an alternative proposal one might adopt under a typical Kratzer (1996)-style approach to argument structure, where thematic Voice is responsible for structural accusative Case. Then, a straightforward account for the case alternation in (1) is that Alternating Verbs project two argument structures: (a) a transitive structure with thematic Voice, where the source is an accusative Case-marked argument, and (b) an unaccusative structure without thematic Voice, where the source is an adjunct, not accusative Case-marked. This is exactly Fukuda’s (2020) proposal. However, such an account goes against a robust generalization in Japanese that verbs participating in a transitive-unaccusative alternation are always distinguished by some verbal morphology (Horvath and Siloni 2011). It also leaves unexplained the observations in Sections 1 and 2.

3 Case assignment

The case alternation exhibited by Alternation Verbs remains to be accounted for. I discuss an account based on dependent case theory (Baker 2015; Baker and Vinokurova 2010; Marantz 1991). Under this view, case is assigned to each NP at Spell-Out. For our purposes, assume the only Spell-Out domain is TP. Each NP is considered for lexical case, dependent case, then unmarked case, in that order. Each rule of case assignment is only considered if the previous rule doesn’t apply. I suggest that *kara* is a lexical ablative case assigned by the ablative postposition (P) head, which is optionally introduced by Alternation Verbs (2). *O* is a dependent accusative case, assigned according to the rule (27). *Ga* is an unmarked nominative case.

- (27) If a NP *X* is not case-marked yet, and it is c-commanded by another NP, then assign accusative to *X*.

When an Alternation Verb doesn’t introduce a prepositional head, the leaver is a NP. At Spell-Out, the leaver isn’t considered for lexical ablative assignment because there is no prepositional head to assign this case. Then, dependent accusative assignment applies because the leaver is c-commanded by the source (28).

- (28) [_{VP} [_{VP} Taro-NOM [_{NP} village-ACC] $\sqrt{\text{LEAVE}}$] v]

When the prepositional head is present, the leaver gets ablative case from it. This bleeds dependent accusative assignment (29).

(29) [_{VP} [_{VP} Taro-NOM [_{PP} village-**from** P] $\sqrt{\text{LEAVE}}$] v]

In contrast to the dependent case-theoretic analysis sketched here, an Agree-based analysis of case would have to say that the *o*-marking on the source is either (a) a lexical/inherent case assigned by the Alternation Verbs, or (b) a structural accusative Case assigned by some functional head. This *o* is likely not lexical but rather structural, because it participates in *Ga/O* Conversion, another case alternation that targets structural accusative *o* for verbs in certain stative forms (30).

(30) Taro-ga kono mura-ga hanare-rare-nai.
 Taro-NOM this village-NOM leave-can-not
 ‘Taro can’t leave this village.’

However, it is difficult to identify a functional head that is responsible for structural *o* assignment in Alternation Verbs that wouldn’t be found in any other unaccusative verb.

4 Conclusion

In this paper, I study the argument structure of a class of Japanese verbs I call Accusative/Ablative Alternation Verbs. I argue that they are dyadic unaccusative verbs. Despite not projecting thematic Voice, they introduce accusative-marked arguments. I suggest that accusative marking is due to dependent case assignment.

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